

“Where Virgil Cannot Go: The Limitations of Reason in Dante’s *Divine Comedy*”

Dante Alighieri’s *Divine Comedy* is a tripartite text layered dizzyingly with philosophical allegory, eminent classical figures, and iconic conceptions of the afterlife. From Inferno Canto I, it is clear that the text is in itself a journey for knowledge; by the end of the text, Dante has pieced together, with staggering vision, a postulation of knowledge of the divine. Reason, by Dante’s treatment, will be taken as the application of human intellect and logic to discern truth. Knowledge, correspondingly, encompasses not only empirical and philosophical understanding but even more so, ultimate, transcendent awareness of the divine order. In *The Divine Comedy*, Dante’s binary of reason and faith does not function as an antithesis between the two modes of knowledge-seeking; it instead adopts a bifurcated approach that functions as a spatial framework for his tripartite journey and recurrent allegory. Dante’s pilgrimage– as both author and protagonist of the text– across ignorance, reason, and faith, leads him and his reader to a penultimate confrontation of reason as a finite, dilute partner to faith in the divine.

There are two places in Dante’s *Divine Comedy* where ignorance and Dante’s commentary on it are particularly salient: the first being the famed opening in the dark wood, and the second being in Limbo, the first circle of Hell. In the dark wood, Dante is in a limbo of his own. The unnatural beginning, “midway along the journey of our life,” and singular but telling usage of a plural pronoun superimpose the reader onto the Pilgrim’s confusion (1.1). Despite the murky beginning– “How I entered there I cannot truly say, / I had become so sleepy at that moment / when I first strayed, leaving the path of truth”– the Pilgrim’s ignorance comes to a point almost as sharply as it begins, as Dante is forced to confront his ignorance in the form of three beasts blocking his upward mobility (1.10-12). His sins obstruct his path to salvation; he

must face them. In Limbo, ignorance is portrayed with similar ambiguity. Souls in Limbo have no marked physical anguish, having been intellectual figures of great virtue and “glory of the sciences and arts” (4.73). Nonetheless, they live in an intermediary state of near-redemption— “[i]n this alone we suffer: / cut off from hope, we live on in desire” (4.41-42). In this sense, ignorance is almost impossible. The individual inevitably must confront what is missing in or obstructing them on their path to knowledge, just as Dante faced the three beasts. Limbo is also mapped with a binary of light and dark, being the one place where light and dark spatially coexist— “up ahead, / a hemisphere of light that lit the dark... // but close enough for me vaguely to see / that honorable souls possessed that spot” (4.68-72). Ignorance could not be further from platitudinous bliss for those in Limbo: “they must live, in desire, without hope of seeing God” for “they have not sinned. But their great worth alone / was not enough” (p. 97n; 4.34-35). Ignorance in *The Divine Comedy* is instead, a state of ambiguous and irresolute tension, intermediary between Paradiso and the depths of Inferno.

Perhaps most accessible in the worldly sense, the early third of the journey traverses knowledge-seeking through reason, for which the poet and guide Virgil functions as an allegory. In Inferno, Dante explores reason misused, reason beyond bounds, and reason as discord; all paths that fall short of divine wisdom, but each correspondent to a different fate. In Canto XVIII, sins of deceit introduce the weaponization of language for personal gain and the distortion of truth and knowledge. Flattery, “there with his words of love, and loving looks,” is connoted with self-centered gain and greed settles into language and reason as media of moral filth— “I am stuck down here by all those flatteries / that rolled unceasing off my tongue up there” (18.91; 18.125-126). Knowledge-seeking via reason is presented as even more dangerous in the fates of the figures in Canto XXVI, “each one swathed in his burning punishment” (26.48). Ulysses,

punished for seeking “experience of what there is beyond” is shown as not only a sinner against classical *pietas*, but an example of knowledge-seeking that comes dangerously close to modern intellectual ambition (26.116). Although he claims to be on a path of “excellence and knowledge,” his pursuit of knowledge is more so marked by pride, ego, and regard for only self-concerned ambition— “you are Greeks!” (26.120; 26.118). Finally, in the deepest circles of Inferno, the pursuit of knowledge by reason arrives at a gruesome warning made in the example of those who spread false knowledge and divisive truth (according to Dante): “the souls that you see passing in this ditch / were all sowers of scandal and schism in life, / and so in death you see them torn asunder” (26.34-36). The decapitation of Bertan in “the perfect *contrapasso*!” is a remarkable allegory for the separation of his “wits” by which he sinned (26.142). Seeking knowledge by reason is not in itself a sin— evidenced by its depiction as virtue in the pagan souls of Limbo— but it is a path that falls short of the divine with sundry pitfalls.

At the summit of Purgatorio, the text comes to a critical juncture at which Virgil is unable to continue as Dante’s guide— a clear parallel for the point at which reason fails in the pursuit of knowledge. As Beatrice takes over, her character an allegory for faith and divine wisdom, several elements clearly set apart those who have made it to Paradiso. In Paradiso Canto I, uplifting, illuminating interplay between sound and light exemplify the other side of Dante’s light-dark binary, so much so that “much more is granted to the human senses / than ever was allowed them here on earth” (1.56-57). Where knowledge-seeking by reason is repeatedly characterized by danger and punishment, the same pursuit but by faith is uplifting and transcendent, from the imitation of Beatrice’s upward gaze (1.64-66; 5.86-87), to the need to “‘transhumanize’— it cannot be explained / *per verba*, so let this example serve / until God’s grace grants the experience” (1.70-72). Reason is distinctly “burdening / ... with misconceptions that prevent /

from seeing clearly what you might have seen” (1.88-90). Across the text, Dante’s binary of reason and faith is not antithetical, but bifurcated. Both are paths that approach knowledge of the divine, but the path of reason seems to lead more often to Inferno, where souls in Paradiso sought knowledge by faith. Of particular note are Trajan, a pagan from Limbo, and Ripheus, a pagan before Christ; respectively, “[o]ne came from Hell... // his belief kindled in him such fire / of the true love that at his second death / he was allowed to join our festival,” and “[t]he other soul, by means of grace... // devoted all his love to righteousness, // ... he saw the light, / and he believed in this” (20.106-117; 20.118-124). The attainment of salvation by these two figures functions as a reassessment of the pursuit of knowledge and its rewards. Even the greatest command of reason is not enough, evidenced by figures like Aristotle being placed in Limbo. It is only through “belief kindled” and “by means of grace” that souls approach the divine.

The rewards of knowledge-seeking by faith are difficult to discern in the text, framed with ineffability topos. The divine in the text fantastically defies human reason; more easily described in its effects on those that approach the divine, than in the divine existence itself. As Beatrice and Dante ascend through the heavenly spheres, Beatrice becomes increasingly radiant—“in the warmth of love, you see me glow / with light the world below has never seen”—as she partakes in the “Eternal Light which, of Itself, / once it is seen, forever kindles love” (5.1-2; 5.8-9). Where reason ends, the ineffable begins, in an apophatic encounter with light so pure it denies definition. This hints at the denouement to the text’s pursuit of knowledge: “for when our intellect draws near its goal / and fathoms to the depths of its desire, / the memory is powerless to follow” (1.7-9). The divine presence, as Dante nears it, recedes into mystery; language fails as apophatic truth resists articulation.

Interposing tripartitions onto binaries, allegory layered beneath it all, Dante’s

metaphysical journey intimates reason and faith as two ways of seeking knowledge; not diametrically opposed but not quite complementary. In the end, where the two diverge in effect, only faith is supplanted by knowledge of the divine and the rewards of the divine presence.

Where Virgil cannot go, where reason falters, faith alone guides the soul to its final beatific vision. In this journey from the dark wood to the Empyrean, Dante offers not a condemnation of reason, but a reordering. In the presence of the ineffable, it is faith— not reason— that grants the unknowable and final truth.

Works Cited

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